

yourself if a teacher is right for you or not. Then there's social media and YouTube. These are great for getting information but not great for assessing the creators' accuracy or trustworthiness. These platforms are driven by algorithms that reward content for how many clicks and views they get, not by how correct or helpful the information is. There are some amazing educators on these platforms—you just have to be careful and do extra vetting outside of them.

On your values-based spending journey, you'll learn from a variety of people. Some will help you spend better, others will help you earn more and learn how to invest it. There is no expert who meets every need for every person. We all need a variety of teachers so we can be sure we're learning the right skills at the right time.

Spending in the Radical Middle

There's nothing worse than when a book gives all this advice that makes total sense in the author's perfect made-up book world but doesn't apply it to the real world, where life is nuanced. You may value one thing over another, but if the lesser is more urgent, what do you choose? You may value something but not be in a season to buy it. What do you spend on, then? The “buy nothing” and “buy everything” extremes are much easier to maintain because the decisions are made for you. But when you reject the extremes at either end of the spectrum, you find the middle.

People glorify extremes in books and on the internet, and they capitalize on them. On one end of the internet, people are saying “Spend as little as possible, pay off debt as quickly as possible, and retire as early as possible!” On the other end, they're saying “Saving is pointless, buy what you want, when you want it!” or “Anyone can make a million dollars a year in my proven real estate investing pyramid-scheme team.” Extremes get the most attention—it's why they go viral on social media. And while we're not against familiarizing yourself with everything that's out there, the all-or-nothing approach is a skill-learning killer. If you want to learn the skills needed to practice values-based spending, you have to transcend the noise of extremes, embrace the nuance, and find your place in the middle. Looking for your middle instead of living in the extremes is a radical concept that, while unlikely to go viral, will help you get the most out of